

Tick Bite - Female (Adult)

Algorithm 1326 | Adult (18 years and older) | Gender at birth: Female

Definition

- Tick bite assessment decomposed from NHS.UK's published Lyme disease guidance.
- Adult patient.
- Female.

Initial assessment

1. [OPEN_TEXT] What is the person's exact age and sex, are they pregnant or immunocompromised, where/when/geographically did exposure occur, is the tick attached/engorged, and are there rash, fever, neurological, cardiac, or joint symptoms?
2. [DURATION] When did the bite happen, or when was the tick found?
3. [YES_NO] Is there a rash or flu-like symptoms?

Triage and redirect questions

1. Redirect → Insect Bite

Is this a non-tick insect bite or sting rather than an attached or recently removed tick?

A bite or sting not caused by a tick belongs in the Insect Bite pathway.

1. Disposition level 70

Within the past 3 months of a tick bite or visiting a high-risk area, is there a round or oval rash, or flu-like symptoms such as feeling hot or cold, shivery, headaches, or aching muscles?

NHS.UK Lyme disease guidance recommends urgent clinical review for these symptoms, which can appear up to 3 months after an infected tick bite.

1. Disposition level 15

Is this a recent tick bite with no rash or flu-like symptoms?

NHS.UK guidance describes safe tick removal as a manageable home first-aid step, with monitoring for delayed symptoms.

Advice

Urgent tick bite follow-up

- Arrange urgent clinical review - if Lyme disease is suspected, antibiotics are more effective when started promptly.
- Call Back If: rash spreads; symptoms worsen.

Safe tick removal and governed follow-up

- Use fine-tipped tweezers or a proper tick tool, grasp close to the skin, and pull steadily upward without twisting, burning, coating, or crushing the tick. Wash hands and the site, record date/location and a photograph if possible, and do not delay care trying to save the tick. Antibiotic testing/treatment, pregnancy and pediatric decisions, imported-travel infections, and Qatar route require governance approval.
- Call Back If: expanding rash, fever, headache, facial weakness, joint swelling, or flu-like illness; site infection or retained mouthparts with worsening inflammation.

First aid

References

- NHS.UK, "Lyme disease", <https://www.nhs.uk/conditions/lyme-disease/> (page last reviewed 03 June 2025)

Provenance

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